



Trinity College Dublin
Coláiste na Tríonóide, Baile Átha Cliath
The University of Dublin

Linguistic Pragmatics LI7862

Thomas Stephen

Trinity College Dublin

Plan for Week 2

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 - dogwhistles as communicative acts

Austin

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- Major text: *How to Do Things with Words* (1962, posthumous).

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 - *I hereby declare the meeting open.*

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- This reframes evaluation:
 - not truth/falsity, but success/failure of an act in context.

Worked example: felicity

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- Procedure: no recognised marriage procedure is underway.
- Authority: the speaker lacks standing to perform the declaration.
- Uptake: others treat it as a joke, not an official act.
- Result: a classic **misfire** (infelicitous), not a false statement.

Exercise: felicity debugging

- For each case:
 - identify what fails (procedure, authority, sincerity, uptake, follow-through),

Exercise: felicity debugging

- For each case:
 - identify what fails (procedure, authority, sincerity, uptake, follow-through),
 - propose a minimal change that would make it felicitous.
- ❶ A student says: *I hereby award you a First.*
- ❷ A stranger says: *I forgive you.* (to someone they have never met)
- ❸ Someone says: *I promise to help you tomorrow* while making clear they have no intention to help.
- ❹ A spectator says: *You're out!* in a sport they are not officiating.

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- A single utterance can have one locution, one illocution, and many perlocutionary effects.

Worked example: locution / illocution / perlocution

Utterance

Can you pass the salt?

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 - the hearer takes the speaker to be polite.

Exercise: separate the layers

- For each mini-dialogue, identify:
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- For each mini-dialogue, identify:
 - the locutionary content,
 - the illocutionary act,
 - two plausible perlocutionary effects.

- ① A: *Are you free to talk?*
B: *I'm walking into a meeting.*
- ② A: *That was a brave thing to say.*
- ③ A (in court): *I object.*

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 - social ontology and institutional facts.

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- Searle's notation:
 - $F(p)$: an illocutionary force F applied to propositional content p .
- The goal is principled classification, not lists of performative verbs.

Searle, J. R. (1976). A classification of illocutionary acts. *Language in Society* 5(1): 1–23.

Searle's diagnostic dimensions (1976)

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- Three dimensions do most of the classificatory work:
 - **Illocutionary point:** what the act is for.
 - **Direction of fit:** how words/world are supposed to line up.
 - **Sincerity condition:** what psychological state is expressed.
- These are designed to be stable across surface forms and across languages.

Direction of fit

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 - represented as ↑
- Some acts have no direction of fit, represented as 0.

Sincerity markers and cognition

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 - what states speakers represent and commit to,
 - what states hearers attribute and track.

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- Examples: *assert, claim, report, conclude, predict*.

Directives

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- Examples: *request, command, ask, advise, urge*.

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Commissives

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- Examples: *promise, vow, pledge, guarantee, offer*.

Expressives

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- Examples: *apologize, thank, congratulate, welcome, deplore*.

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 - *The meeting is adjourned.*

Searle's taxonomy: summary table

Type	Point	Fit	Sincerity
Representatives	commit to truth	↓	<i>B</i>
Directives	get H to act	↑	<i>W</i>
Commissives	commit S to act	↑	<i>I</i>
Expressives	express attitude	0	varies
Declarations	change institutions	special	authority/procedure

- The goal is a disciplined way of justifying classifications, including borderline cases.

Exercises

Exercise: classify and justify

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- For each item:
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 - justify using point + direction of fit + sincerity,
 - give one plausible alternative and the context that would support it.

- ① *I hereby resign from the committee.*
- ② *Could you close the window?*
- ③ *I'm afraid you have the wrong number.*
- ④ *I'll send you the draft by Friday.*
- ⑤ *Congratulations on the job offer!*

Discussion: speech acts in institutions

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 - *globalists*

Saul (2018, 2019).

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- Both rely on concealment from at least some audience members.

Saul (2019).

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- Defusing strategy:
 - make the target meaning explicit in public, forcing accountability.

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 - publicly accuse the speaker of racism (or other relevant prejudice),
 - triggering self-monitoring and weakening the covert effect.

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Saul (2019).

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- Defusing attempts can be dismissed as overreach while mobilisation continues.

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Dogwhistles as communicative acts: felicity and failure

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- See also: *Topoi* 42 (2023): 445–458.

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Wrap-up

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- Setting up implicature and later post-Gricean theories.

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